▶ RAJASTHAN

GRAND OLD WARPATH

All gloves are off in Rajasthan, as the Congress goes hell for leather against the Bhajan Lal Sharma regime, and finds itself being strafed by the ED

By **Rohit Parihar**

IN RAJASTHAN, OPPOSITION PARTIES typically lie low after an electoral trouncing, licking their wounds. But the Congress has bucked that trend with uncharacteristic bellicosity. Spurred by its 'strongest defeat' in a long time—currently, it holds 69 of Rajasthan's 200 assembly seats—the Grand Old Party has kept Bhajan Lal Sharma's BJP government off-kilter with a blitz of warlike steps, ranging from assembly disruptions to scathing public attacks. PCC chief Govind Singh Dotasra, in fact, embodied this martial spirit perhaps too spiritedly, charging at Speaker Vasudev Devnani's chair during a session—earning himself a week's suspension.

For good measure, former CM Ashok Gehlot and his former deputy Sachin Pilot have also closed ranks. Partaking of the offensive, Gehlot accuses the BJP regime of scuppering his welfare schemes. Young gun Tika Ram Jully, a spunky leader of Opposition, even successfully prosecuted a political trial of the ruling party for casteism. That was after BJP ex-MLA Gyan Dev Ahuja sprinkled Gangajal at a Ram temple after Congress leaders—including Jully, a Dalit—participated in its consecration ceremony.

But the BJP has now hit back, with the Enforcement Directorate moving against two Congress ex-ministers. The first: Pratap Khachariyawas. His broadside on the state's Rs 100 crore spend on a film awards jamboree in March degenerated into digs at deputy CM Diya Kumari as an old chit fund scam case haunted him. Two: Mahesh Joshi, with some tainted Jal Jeevan tenders. The gloves are truly off. ■

Takeaways

- **Two Congress ex-ministers get old graft cases raked up, as BJP ups its return offensive**
- **This was after a barrage of salvos against the BJP regime by a spirited, united GOP**



AFP

ESCALATION LADDER
Sachin Pilot, Govind Dotasra and Tika Jully at a Congress function



AFP

By **Kaleem Geelani**

THE 'GARDEN OF EDEN' was in full bloom just the other day, a million wonder-struck eyes taking in its late spring beauty. But first Pahalgam broke over the landscape like an unannounced typhoon, taking the life out of Kashmir's verdant valleys, shimmering waters and bustling streets. Now intimations of war, after Operation Sindoor, have taken the Union territory back to being a frontline crackling with fire.

BACK TO THE EDGE

Things were dire even in the tense days leading up to India's strikes. "Almost 90 per cent of bookings were cancelled," says Suhail Dar, who runs the travel agency Kashmir Travel Advisor. "A high-end group of 21 cancelled their April 28 booking right after Pahalgam. This was the pattern. We're in total distress."

Now, with the Srinagar airport among those shut, no